Fences

By August Wilson

TROY: **(Pg 12)** When I met this woman . . . I latched on to her. I latched on to her and told her "Baby, I don't wanna marry, I just wanna be your man. She told me . . "You in my way. You blocking the view! Move out the way so I can find me a husband." I though it over. . . Come back, told her "Okay, baby . . ."

ROSE: **(Pg 90)** When I first met [him] I was thirty years old and had done seen my share of men. But when he walked up to me and said, "I can dance a waltz that'll make you dizzy," I thought, Rose Lee, here is a man that you can open yourself up to and be filled to bursting. Here is a man that can fill all them empty spaces you been tipping around the edges of.

TROY: **(Pg 60)** She a good woman. I been married to her for eighteen years. She done carried me a long ways and I love and respect her for that. *(pause)* You can't find a better woman than Rose. I know that.

ROSE: **(Pg 91)** When he walked through the house he was so big he filled it up. That was my first mistake. Not to make him leave some room for me. But at that time I wanted that. All wanted a house that I could sing in. And that's what he gave me. I didn't know to keep up his strength I had to give up little pieces of mine. I did that. **(Pg 63)** Well, everybody got their own way of looking at it I guess.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Pittsburg, Pennsylvania 1950*
ACTRESS: *It's the beginning of the Civil Rights movement. And Troy and Rose Maxson are struggling. Struggling in life and in this scene struggling with their marriage.*
ACTOR: *What is it that makes a marriage? Love? Responsibility?*
ACTRESS: *And what can destroy it? Selfishness? Infidelity?*
ACTOR: *At the heart of Fences by August Wilson is a question that transcends race . . .*
ACTRESS: *What is our responsibility to ourselves versus to our family and society?*
TOGETHER: *Fences by August Wilson*

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ROSE: (Pg 63 +) *(enters scene with Troy)* Come on and get your lunch. I got a bowl of lima beans and some cornbread in the oven. Come on get something to eat. *(Rose turns to go into the house)*

TROY: Rose . . . got something to tell you. *(she stops and turns around)* I don't know how to say this. *(pause)* Can't explain it none. It just sort of grows on you till it gets out of hand. It starts out like a little bush . . . and the next think you know it's a whole forest.

ROSE: Troy . . . what is you talking about?

TROY: I'm talking, woman, let me talk. I'm trying to find a way to tell you . . . I'm gonna be a daddy. I'm gonna be somebody's daddy.

ROSE: Troy . . . you're not telling me this? You're gonna be . . . what? You telling me you gonna be somebody's daddy? You telling your ***wife*** this?

TROY: Rose . . . it's just . . .

ROSE: Why, Troy? Why? After all these years to come draggin' this in to me now. It don't make no sense at your age. I could have expected this ten or fifteen years ago, but not now.

TROY: Age ain't got nothing to do with it, Rose.

ROSE: I done tried to be everything a wife should be. You know I ain't never wanted no half nothing in my family. My whole family is half. Everybody got different fathers and mothers . . . my two sisters and my brother. Can't hardly tell who's who. It's your papa and your mama and my papa and my mama . . . And now you wanna drag your behind in here and tell me something like this.

TROY: You ought to know. It's time for you to know.

ROSE: Well, I don't want to know, goddamn it!

TROY: I can't just make it go away. It's done now. I can't wish the circumstance of the thing away.

ROSE: And you don't want to either. Maybe you want to wish me away. Maybe that's what you want? Well, you cant. I've got eighteen years of my life invested in you. You ought to have stayed upstairs in my bed where you belong.

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TROY: Rose . . . now listen to me . . . we can get a handle on this thing. We can talk this out. . . come to an understanding.

ROSE: All of a sudden it's "we." Where was "we" at when you was down there rolling around with some godforsaken woman? "We" should have come to an understanding before you started making a damn fool of yourself. You're a day late and a dollar short when it comes to an understanding with me.

TROY: It's just . . . She gives me a different idea . . .a different understanding about myself. I can step out of this house and get away from the pressures and problems. . . be a different man. I ain't got to wonder how I'm gonna pay the bills or get the roof fixed. I can just be a part of myself that I ain't never been.

ROSE: What I want to know. . . is do you plan to continue seeing her? That's all you can say to me.

TROY: I can sit up in her house and laugh. Do you understand what I'm saying. I can laugh out loud . . .and it feels good. It reaches all the way down to the bottom of my shoes. *(pause)* Rose, I can't give that up.

ROSE: Maybe you ought to go on and stay down there with her . . . if she a better woman then me.

TROY: It ain't about noboby being a better woman or nothing. Rose, you aint the blame. A man couldn't ask for no woman to be a better wife than you've been. I'm responsible for it. I done locked myself into a pattern trying to take care of you that I forgot about myself.

ROSE: What the hell was I there for? That was my job, not somebody's else's.

TROY: Rose, I done tried all my life to live decent . . . to live a clean . . . hard . . .useful life. I tried to be a good husband to you. In every way I knew how. Maybe I come into the world backwards, I don't know. But . . . you born with two strikes on you before you come to the plate. You got to guard it closely . . . always looking for the curve-ball on the inside corner. You dan't afford to let none get past you. If you going down . . you going down swinging. Everything lined up against you. (Pause) I fooled them, Rose. I bunted. When I found you and a halfway decent job . . . I was safe. Couldn't nothing touch me. I wasn't gonna strike

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out no more. I wasn't going back to the penitentiary. I wasn't gonna lay in the streets with a bottle of wine. I was safe. I had me a family. A job. I wasn't gonna get that last strike. I was on first looking for one of them boys to knock me in. To get me home.

ROSE: You should have stayed in my bed, Troy.

TROY: Then when I saw that gal . . . she firmed up my backbone. And I got to thinking that if I tried . . . I just might be able to steal second. Do you understand after eighteen years I wanted to steal second. I stood on first base of eighteen years and I thought . . . well, goddamn it . . go for it!

ROSE: We're not talking about baseball! We're talking about you going off to lay in bed with another woman . . and then bring it home to me. That's what we're talking about. We ain't talking about no baseball!

TROY: Rose, you're not listening to me. I'm trying the best I can to explain it to you. It's not easy for me to admit that I been standing in the same place for eighteen years.

ROSE: I been standing with you! I gave eighteen years of my life to stand in the same spot with you. Don't you think I ever wanted other things? Don't you think I had dreams and hopes? What about my life? What about me. Don't you think it ever crossed my mind to want to know other men? That I wanted to lay up somewhere and forget about my responsibilities? That I wanted someone to make me laugh so I could feel good? You not the only one who's got wants and needs. But I held on to you, Troy. I took all my feelings, my wants and needs, my dreams . . . and I buried them inside you. I planted a seed and waited and prayed over it. I planted myself inside you and waited to bloom, and it didn't take me no eighteen years to find out the soil was hard and rocky and it wasn't never gonna bloom. But I held on to you, Troy, I held you tighter. Cause you was my husband. Cause that's the only way I was gonna survive . . . as your wife. You always talking about what you give . . .and what you don't have to give. But you take too. You take. . . and don't even know nobody's giving! *(Rose turns to exit; Troy grabs her arm)*

TROY: You say I take and don't give!

ROSE: Troy . . . you're hurting my arm! Let go!

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TROY: I done give you everything I got. Don't you tell that lie on me.

ROSE: Troy!

TROY: Don't you tell that lie on me! Don't you tell me about no taking and giving. *(releases her arm roughly) (Long beat)*

ROSE: *(gathers her strength)* Tomorrow's Friday. I want to know if you're coming home.

TROY: I'm going over to the hospital to see Alberta. She went into the hospital this afternoon. Look like she might have the baby early. I won't be gone long.

(The telephone is heard ringing inside the house; Rose exits into the house to answer the telephone. While she is gone, Troy picks up a baseball bat from beneath the tree and takes some practice swings. She returns)

ROSE: Troy . . . that was the hospital. Alberta had the baby. *(Pause)* It's a girl.

TROY: I better get on down to the hospital to see her.

ROSE: Troy . . .

TROY: Rose . . . I got to go see her now. That's only right . . . what's the matter . . . the baby's all right, ain't it?

ROSE: Alberta died having the baby.

TROY: Died . . . you say she's dead? Albert'a dead?

ROSE: They said they done all they could. *(Troy exits)*

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(PG 73) *(Rose is on the porch waiting for Troy. He enters the yard carrying an infant wrapped in blankets; awkward silence)*

TROY: Rose . . . I'm standing here with my daughter in my arms. She ain't but a wee bittie little old thing. She don't know nothing about grownups' business. She innocent . . . and she ain't got no mama.

ROSE: What you telling me for, Troy? *(She turns away)*

TROY: Well . . . A man's got to do what's right for him. I ain't sorry for nothing I done. It felt right in my heart. *(Pause)* She's my daughter, Rose. My own flesh and blood. I can't deny her. *(Pause)* You is my family. You and this child is all I got in the world. So I guess what I'm saying is . . . I'd appreciate it if you'd help me take care of her. *(He hands the baby to Rose)*

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ROSE: *(She is torn, but her motherly instinct kicks in)* Okay, Troy . . . you're right. You can't visit the sins of the father upon the child. A motherless child has got a hard time. From right now . . . this child got a mother. But you a womanless man. *(She motions for Troy to leave. He does; she watches him walk away, then speaks to the audience)* **(Pg 90- 91)** I took on his life as mine and mixed up the pieces so that you couldn't hardly tell which was which anymore. It was my choice. It was my life and I didn't have to live it like that. But that's what life offered me in the way of being a woman and I took it. I grabbed hold of it with both hands. He meant to do more good than he meant to do harm. He wasn't always right. Sometimes when he touched he bruised. And sometimes when he took me in his arms he cut. *(Looking at the baby in her arms)* By the time Raynell came into the house, we had done lost touch with one another. I didn't want to make my blessing off of nobody's misfortune . . . but I took on to Raynell like she was all them babies I had wanted and never had. . . . I'm gonna give her the best of what's in me.

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AWARD HISTORY

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2008 National Qualifier
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